

Qroo Paul's Spanish Master Course

Lesson 14 Summary

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In this lesson, Qroo Paul explains the two main verbs in Spanish that both translate as "to know": *saber* and *conocer*. While they may seem interchangeable in English, they have different meanings and uses in Spanish. The lesson also revisits important patterns like *tener que*, *querer*, and how to use infinitives after certain verbs.

SABER – to know facts, information, or how to do something

Use *saber* when talking about things that can be learned, remembered, or explained:

Examples:

¿Sabes dónde está el hotel? – Do you know where the hotel is?

Sí, yo sé dónde está el hotel. – Yes, I know where the hotel is.

¿Sabes si Juan tiene que trabajar el viernes? – Do you know if Juan has to work on Friday?

Conjugation of SABER (Present Tense)

yo sé

tú sabes

él / ella sabe

nosotros sabemos

ustedes saben

(*vosotros sabéis* is used only in Spain)

Saber + infinitive = to know how to do something

¿Sabes nadar? – Do you know how to swim?

Sí, sé nadar. – Yes, I know how to swim.

¿Sabe cocinar María? – Does María know how to cook?

You can also say:

No sé nadar, pero quiero aprender. – I don't know how to swim, but I want to learn.

**** **Saber cómo + infinitive** – is used “to know how to do something” when referring to a process or the specific steps of doing something: ¿Sabes cómo encontrar el nombre del vecino en la base de datos? (Do you know how to find the neighbor's name in the database?)

Word Order Tips:

If a sentence begins with a question word like *qué* or *quién*, the subject follows the verb:

¿Qué sabe Juan? – What does Juan know?

But without a question word, the subject can appear before or after:

¿Sabe cocinar María? or ¿María sabe cocinar?

CONOCER – to know or be familiar with people, places, or things

Use *conocer* when referring to being acquainted with a person, having visited a place, or being familiar with a song, book, etc.

Examples:

¿Conoces a Juan? – Do you know Juan?

Sí, conozco a Juan. – Yes, I know Juan.

¿Quieres conocer a Juan? – Do you want to meet Juan?

Conjugation of CONOCER (Present Tense)

yo conozco

tú conoces

él / ella conoce

nosotros conocemos

ustedes conocen

(*vosotros conocéis* is used only in Spain)

Important Note: The personal "a"

When *conocer* is used with a person or pet, you must use the personal *a*:

¿Conoces a María? – Do you know María?

¿Tienes que conocer a Juan? – Do you have to meet Juan?

Places and Things:

When *conocer* is used with places, it typically means you've been there or are familiar with it:

¿Conoces México? – Have you been to / Are you familiar with Mexico?

When referring to being aware that something exists (not necessarily being familiar with it), a better phrase might be:

¿Has oído hablar del museo? – Have you heard of the museum?

When talking about *facts* related to things (e.g., lyrics of a song), use *saber*:

¿Sabes la letra de la canción? – Do you know the lyrics?

But for general familiarity:

¿Conoces la canción? – Are you familiar with the song?

Mixing SABER and CONOCER:

¿Sabes si Juan conoce a María? – Do you know if Juan knows María?

This lesson builds on previous ones and shows how plugging in new verbs and patterns lets you build more complex and natural Spanish sentences. For extra practice, refer to the worksheet included with the video inside the Qroo Spanish Crew.